

HOW TO... MAKE A NEW IDEA POPULAR

Widely publicize
the benefits
before launch.

Offer sneak
previews, trials, or
training sessions.

Get early users
to persuade
other people.

Use your user
feedback to
adapt innovation.

Listing characteristics

Certain key characteristics greatly affect how easily an innovation can be diffused. The first is relative advantage: how much better the new innovation is perceived to be. People will be more eager to adopt an idea if its benefits are obvious. Balanced against this is complexity: the more difficult people perceive the innovation to be (the more complex the procedure, the more technical the product) the less likely they will be to adopt it. Other important factors are visibility—it can be useful to offer demonstrations of the benefits of your new idea—and whether it can be trialed—training and trial runs are important to help users come to terms with new products and procedures. Finally, the product must be compatible with the market—it must fit the people who you want to adopt it. Try to minimize any mismatch by developing variants for different groups of user.

Understanding early adopters

Innovation adoption is a complex negotiation between proponents of an innovation and the people they want to use it. Some people can be relied upon to be enthusiastic and try out new products, while others will resist changes to their settled preferences. To accelerate diffusion of your innovation you need to know the types of adopter and what motivates them. Your best friends will be innovators—cutting-edge users who are always willing to try new products and processes. They can be recruited during testing stages, working with prototypes and beta versions, and may also come up with ideas for improvement. The next are early adopters—trendsetters in a community whom others imitate. They are often open to good new ideas, and should be targeted because if you can appeal to them and meet their needs, others are likely to follow.